

5-Day Economics and Policy Workshop

Student Syllabus | 90 Minutes Per Session

About This Workshop

This workshop uses real life and policy examples to show how economics shapes the world around you — from everyday choices to climate change, global trade, and financial markets. No prior economics knowledge required.

What You'll Leave With

The ability to apply economic thinking to real decisions and policies — and to spot the hidden trade-offs, data tricks, and mental shortcuts that shape how people (and markets) behave.

Course Schedule

Day 1 — Economic Decision Making & Everyday Choices

- Concepts: trade-offs, opportunity cost, sunk costs, incentives
- Activity: Weekend Planning — design the best weekend under real constraints
- Policy debate: Should New Haven schools ban cell phones?

Day 2 — Economics & Data

- Concepts: correlation vs. causation, confounding variables, selection bias
- Game: work through a classic confounding-variable puzzle
- Activity: Chart Detective — analyze real misleading charts

Day 3 — Climate Change & Common Resources

- Concepts: common resources, externalities, tragedy of the commons, government policy tools
- Game: Candy Commons — experience the tragedy of the commons
- Policy debate: Should the U.S. impose a carbon tax?

Day 4 — Trade & Tariffs

- Concepts: gains from trade, imports and exports, tariffs,
- Game: Candy Trading — experience why voluntary trade makes both sides better off
- Policy debate: Are U.S. steel tariffs worth it? Read real sources and defend a position

Day 5 — Behavioral Finance

- Concepts: gambler's fallacy, hot-hand thinking, loss aversion, anchoring, herding
- Activities: coin flip predictions, fake stock chart analysis, mini market simulation
- Takeaway: design your own decision rule to guard against a bias in real life